

5

Reported statements

5.1 Look at the two conversations below:

Situation 1: October 21

Emma met Sally. Here is their conversation.



What do you think about my story?

It's interesting.
I enjoyed it a lot.



Situation 2: October 22

Paul met Emma. Here is their conversation.



Has Sally read your story?

Yes. She said, 'It's interesting. I enjoyed it a lot'.



In reply to Paul's question, Emma repeats word-for-word what Sally told her the day before. She uses **direct speech**.

Situation 3: October 22

Wesley met Emma later the same day. Here is their conversation.



Has Sally made any comments about your story?

Yes. She told me that it was interesting and that she had enjoyed it a lot.



This time Emma does not repeat Sally's exact words. She instead tells Wesley the meaning of what Sally said to her. She uses **reported speech**. In this unit you will practise changing direct statements into **reported speech**.

5.2 Reporting verbs

We often use the reporting verb **tell** (somebody) to report what someone said earlier. The reporting verb is usually in the simple past tense. This is followed by a **that-clause**.

Direct: 'I don't know anything about cars,' she said to me.

Reported: She **told** me **that she didn't know anything about cars**.

If we do not mention who is spoken to, we often use **say** instead of **tell**.

Direct: 'Sam is late again,' Yvonne said.

Reported: Yvonne **said** **that Sam was late again**.



Note

- 1 The word **that** after the reporting verb can be omitted.

Direct: 'Mr Chan is out of town,' his secretary told me.

Reported: Mr Chan's secretary **told** me **(that) Mr Chan was out of town**.

The word **that** is often omitted when we use an informal style.

- 2 We can also use **say something to somebody**.

Direct: 'Welcome, everybody,' the host said.

Reported: The host **said welcome to us**.

Compare: What did he **say** to you?

What did he **tell** you?

Besides **tell** and **say**, we can also use other reporting verbs such as **admit**, **agree**, **promise**, **ask**, etc. depending on the meaning.

Direct: 'I've stolen the money,' Jack said.

Reported: Jack **admitted** **(that) he had stolen the money**.

The past continuous tense changes to the past perfect continuous tense (i.e. **had been + -ing** form of the verb) in reported speech.

Direct: 'It **was raining**,' Kelly said.

Reported: Kelly said it **had been raining**.

5.3 Change of tense

When we report what someone said at an earlier time, we usually need to change the tense of the verb.

However, sometimes the past continuous tense does not change, especially when the order in which things happened is clear.

Direct: 'I **was watching** TV when the bell **rang**,' Danny said.

Reported: Danny said he **was watching** TV when the bell **rang**.

Direct speech	Reported speech
Simple present 'Lucy is sick,' Ivy told us.	→ Simple past Ivy told us (that) Lucy was sick.
Present continuous 'I'm texting my friends,' Tom said.	→ Past continuous Tom said (that) he was texting his friends.
Present perfect 'Bill has arrived safely,' she told Sam.	→ Past perfect (i.e. had + past participle form of the verb) She told Sam (that) Bill had arrived safely.

Direct speech	Reported speech
Simple past 'Issac didn't tell me about the meeting,' Jim said.	→ Past perfect (i.e. <i>had</i> + past participle form of the verb) Jim said (that) Isaac hadn't told him about the meeting.
<i>will</i> 'I'll be there on time,' she promised.	→ <i>would</i> She promised (that) she would be there on time.



Note

- 1 If the reporting verb is in the present tense, no tense changes are necessary.

Direct: 'I **love** you,' Mrs Lam always **tells** her kids.

Reported: Mrs Lam always **tells** her kids (that) she **loves** them.

- 2 Sometimes the simple past tense does not change. This happens when the time something happened is specified, like *in 2016* or *when I was small*.

Direct: 'I **lived** on Cheung Chau *when I was small*,' she said.

Reported: She mentioned (that) she **lived** on Cheung Chau *when she was small*.

- 3 A fact that is still true can be reported as told, in the simple present tense as well as the simple past tense.

Direct: 'I **am** a doctor,' said Kevin.

Reported: Kevin said he **is/was** a doctor.

It is possible to use the simple present tense/simple past tense in the reported statement if what is reported is still true or the situation has not changed. Nevertheless, if we are not sure about the truth of what the speaker said, or we want to emphasize that we got the information from the speaker himself/herself, we tend to use the simple past tense.

5.4 Changes of pronouns and possessive adjectives

When we use **reported speech**, we often need to make changes to pronouns and possessive adjectives (*my, your*, etc.).

Direct speech	Reported speech
I, me, my	he/she, him/her, his/her
we, us, our	they, them, their
you, your	I/he/she/they, me/him/her/them, my/his/her/their
mine/yours, ours/yours	his/hers, theirs

For example:

Direct speech	Reported speech
'I'll join you ,' she said to him.	She told him (that) she would join him .
' We 've waited for you all day long,' they said to Newton.	They complained to Newton (that) they had waited for him all day long.
'I haven't received your email,' Jenny told me.	Jenny told me (that) she hadn't received my email.



Note

The changes depend on the situation.

Direct speech	Reported speech
'I'll borrow your backpack,' I said.	I told you (that) I would borrow your backpack.
'I left your camera on the bus,' David said to Ada.	David told Ada (that) he had left her camera on the bus.
'I've marked your test papers,' Miss Wong told us.	Miss Wong told us (that) she had marked our test papers.
'I saw your sister on Sunday,' I said to Kyle.	I told Kyle (that) I had seen his sister on Sunday.

5.5 Changes of adverbs and adverbial phrases of time and place

We also need to change adverbs and adverbial phrases of time and place, and reference words **this**, **these**, etc. when we use **reported speech**.

Direct speech	Reported speech
here	there
this	that/the
these	those/the
now	then/at the time
today	that day
tonight	that night
this evening/week/month/year	that evening/week/month/year
tomorrow	the next day/the following day
yesterday	the day before/the previous day
the day before yesterday	two days before/two days earlier
ago (three days ago, etc.)	before (three days before, etc.)
last night/Monday/week/month/year	the previous night/Monday/week/month/year
next Monday/week/month/year	the following Monday/week/month/year

For example:

Direct speech	Reported speech
'We'll meet here tomorrow ,' Mary told Jimmy.	Mary told Jimmy (that) they would meet there the next day .
'David was here yesterday ,' she told us.	She told us (that) David had been there the day before .
'I bought these T-shirts from this online shop last week ,' Ted said.	Ted said (that) he had bought those/the T-shirts from that/the online shop the previous week .

Note

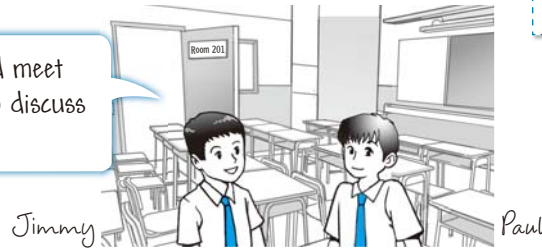
As usual, the changes depend on differences in time and place. Consider this:

Monday morning



Monday afternoon

Mary said we would meet here tomorrow to discuss the project.



Tuesday morning

Are you sure we are meeting in Room 201 to discuss the project?



PRACTICE

A You are at home. Tell your parents what these people said during lunchtime yesterday (Tuesday). Use **reported speech**.

1



I don't like detective stories.

Jeff

Jeff told me (that) he doesn't like/didn't like detective stories.

2



It's very hot today.

Kate

Kate complained (that) it was very hot yesterday/yesterday that it was very hot.

3



Our maths teacher
is very friendly.

Doris

Doris from Class 2E said (that) their maths teacher is/was very
friendly.

4



My hamster passed
away yesterday.

Sophia

Sophia told me yesterday (that) her hamster (had) passed
away the day before/the previous day.

5



I plan to go hiking
this Sunday.

Peggy

Peggy told me (that) she plans to/planned to go hiking this
Sunday.

✗ that Sunday (It is only Wednesday today. Sunday has not yet passed.)

6



I finished the project
two days ago.

Jason

Jason said (that) he (had) finished the project two days before.

7



Oscar is playing
basketball with his
friends on the court.

Rebecca

Oscar's classmate Rebecca told me (that) Oscar/he was playing
basketball with his friends on the court (then/at that time/at the time).

8



I have lost
my phone.

Kenny

Kenny told me (that) he had lost his phone.

9



You need to hand
in your project
next Monday.

Miss Chan

Miss Chan reminded us yesterday (that) we need to/needed
to hand in our project next Monday.

✗ the following Monday (It is only Wednesday today. Next Monday is coming.)

B Your classmates said different things at the school picnic yesterday. Peter did not go to the picnic because he did not feel well. Peter is now on the phone. Tell him what these people said using **reported speech**. The first two have been done for you as examples.

- 1 Jason to the class teacher: 'It's a great place for a picnic.'
- 2 Alan: 'There are many beautiful shells at this beach.'
- 3 Sally: 'I love looking at the sea.'
- 4 Joan to you: 'I've never tried avocados.'
- 5 Kenneth to Leigh: 'I had a barbecue party with my cousins here last month.'
- 6 Maurice to Joe: 'My sister is studying abroad.'
- 7 Fiona to Kenny: 'I can't open this bottle.'
- 8 Greg: 'My brother also enjoys going to the beach.'

- 1 Jason said to the class teacher (that) it was a great place for a picnic.
- 2 Alan told me there were many beautiful shells at that beach.
- 3 Sally sat on a rock and commented (that) she loves/loved looking at the sea.
- 4 I asked Joan if she like avocados. She answered (that) she had never tried them/avocados
_____.
- 5 Leigh asked Kenneth if he had been to that beach before. Kenneth said (that) he had had a
barbecue party with his cousins there the month before/the previous month.
- 6 Joe asked Maurice how his sister was doing. Maurice told him (that) his sister was studying abroad
_____.
- 7 Fiona tried to open a bottle of water but failed. She told Kenny (that) she couldn't open that/
the bottle.
- 8 Greg told me (that) his brother also enjoyed/enjoys going to the beach.

C Mark has interviewed a few students for a survey about school facilities. Here are quotes from three of the students:

Shirley Poon, Class 3B

My favourite place at school is the art room. I can find all the drawing tools and other things I need there whenever I feel creative. My least favourite place is the girls' toilet on the ground floor because it never flushes properly. The school needs to do something about it!

Edward Chow, Class 4B

It's a pity that the school doesn't have a drama studio. I'm a drama club member, and I always have to look for empty classrooms to practise in with other club members after school. It's almost impossible for us to practise during lunchtimes because there isn't a room available.

William Lo, Class 2C

Overall I think our school has good facilities, but one problem for me is that there are not enough badminton rackets for students to use. I have never been able to borrow one after school because my classroom is on the top floor and I always get to the sports ground a few minutes later than all the other students who go there.

Mark would like to include what they said in his survey report. Help him complete this part of his report by changing what the respondents said into **reported speech**.

Shirley Poon from Class 3B said that her favourite place at school ⁽¹⁾ was the art room because ⁽²⁾ she could find all the drawing tools and other things she needed there whenever she felt creative.

She added that her least favourite place ⁽³⁾ was the girls' toilet on the ground floor because ⁽⁴⁾ it never flushed properly. She believes ⁽⁵⁾ the school needs to do something about it.

Edward Chow from Class 4B said that it was a pity that the school ⁽⁶⁾ did not have a drama studio. He said that he was a drama club member, and ⁽⁷⁾ he always had to look for empty classrooms to practise in with other club members after school. He added that ⁽⁸⁾ it was almost impossible for them to practise during lunchtimes because ⁽⁹⁾ there was not a room available.

William Lo from Class 2C told me that overall ⁽¹⁰⁾ he thought our school had/has good facilities, but one problem ⁽¹¹⁾ was that there were not enough badminton rackets for students to use. He said that ⁽¹²⁾ he had never been able to borrow one after school because his classroom was on the top floor and he always got to the sports ground a few minutes later than all the other students who went there.

D *The following is part of the script for the play 'The Stolen Documents'. It is a conversation between Bernice, a detective, and her client, Frank.*

SCENE 1: LIBRARY OF A MANSION. NOON.

[BERNICE and FRANK are at centre stage]

Frank Here it is. This is the drawer where I put the documents before they disappeared. I'm sure it was locked last night.

Bernice Let me see ... hmm, it seems that someone opened the drawer with a key. Who was the last person that left the house?

Frank Raymond, my secretary, was the last person that left the house. But it couldn't have been him. He doesn't have a key.

Bernice What if he duplicated the key?

Frank That's impossible as well. I've never handed the key to him under any circumstances.

[BERNICE notices something on the floor. She bends down and picks it up.]

Bernice Wait, what do we have here on the floor? A hairpin. Interesting. A skilful thief can pick a lock with this. Was there a woman in your house yesterday?

Frank Well, Mrs Robin, my housekeeper, was here yesterday morning. But she had the afternoon off and wasn't back until this morning.

Bernice I see. Who else was in your house yesterday?

[FRANK rubs his hands uncomfortably.]

Frank My son came to visit me. We can rule him out though. He had no reason to steal the documents.

[BERNICE shakes her head.]

Bernice I'm afraid we can't rule anybody out, not even your son. There is no sign of a break-in, so I believe the documents were stolen by someone you know.

[FRANK sighs.]

You wish to adapt the play into a novel. Write this part of the story using **reported speech**.

Bernice the detective was standing in the library of Frank's mansion. A drawer, originally locked, was now open. Documents previously kept inside were gone. Frank told Bernice that he was sure the drawer ⁽¹⁾ had been locked the night before. Bernice checked the lock. She believed that someone ⁽²⁾ had opened the drawer with a key. Frank told her that Raymond the secretary ⁽³⁾ had been the last person that had left the house, but he thought it was impossible for Raymond to have stolen the documents because he did not have a key to the drawer. Bernice suggested that he could have duplicated the key, but Frank told her that was not possible either because ⁽⁴⁾ he had never handed the key to Raymond under any circumstances.

Just then, Bernice noticed something on the floor. She bent down and picked it up. It was a hairpin. She told Frank that a skilful thief ⁽⁵⁾ could pick a lock with that, and she asked if there had been a woman in his house the day before. Frank answered ⁽⁶⁾ (that) his housekeeper Mrs Robin had been there the previous morning, but ⁽⁷⁾ she had had the afternoon off and had not been back until that morning.

Bernice went on to ask who else had been in the house. Frank began to rub his hands uncomfortably. He said ⁽⁸⁾ (that) his son had come to visit him. He added that they ⁽⁹⁾ could rule him out, because his son ⁽¹⁰⁾ (had) had no reason to steal the documents. However, Bernice shook her head. She insisted that they ⁽¹¹⁾ could not rule anybody out, not even his son. She reminded him ⁽¹²⁾ (that) there was no sign of a break-in, so she believed ⁽¹³⁾ (that) the documents had been stolen by someone he knew. Frank sighed.

USING THE LANGUAGE

We use **reported statements** to talk about things people have said without quoting their exact words. We can use them in, for example, a magazine article to report people's opinions. We can also use them in a letter of complaint to describe a conversation. Look at the examples below. Note the uses of **reported statements** in bold.

Magazine article (excerpt)

Views are mixed. Lily said **that she had visited two food trucks the previous month**. She reported **that the food was delicious**. However, she noted **that the menu was limited**, and she complained **that the trucks had been hard to find**. Max, another food truck customer, agreed **that the scheme had its problems**.

Letter of complaint (excerpt)

The salesperson told me **that they did not have the shirt in my size**, so I decided to buy the large I had tried on. However, he said **that the large one looked sloppy on me and that I should not buy it!** I told him **that I thought he was rude**. Then he said **I could make a complaint if I was dissatisfied with his service**.



Your teacher asks you to write an article for the school magazine about the new tuck shop at your school using **reported statements**. Begin with the given words. Do not write more than 120 words.

The new tuck shop has opened, and most students love it. Callie Mak said that the instant noodles were delicious. Her friend Billy Lam added that **they had already eaten three bowls each**. Other students reported that the siu mai, pork buns and waffles were all tasty. However, a few noted that service was sometimes slow, and one student complained that his siu mai had come cold. The shop manager, Jane Wong, replied that the staff were still learning. She said that the shop had interviewed dozens of students and teachers on its opening day, and that 96% of the feedback had been positive. She promised that service would improve and said she would continue to welcome opinions from students and teachers.

(accept any reasonable answer)